

Chapter 79-1

Xu Qingzhu's words had backed Su Zhe into a corner.

At the same time, Su Zhe stared at her, lost in thought. It was Meng Tong who pulled him back to reality.

Meng Tong tugged at his sleeve. "What are you thinking about?"

Su Zhe looked at Meng Tong, so agitated that he was incoherent. "Look at her.. doesn't she look like Yaoyao?"

Meng Tong pursed her lips and nodded. "She's Yaoyao's daughter to begin with. Isn't it normal for her to look like her?"

Su Zhe said, "It's different. Just now, she..."

His words suddenly stopped there.

It was like a drama reaching its climax and then abruptly ending.

Su Zhe's expression changed several times, and then he looked at Xu Qingzhu and sighed. "You're right."

Xu Qingzhu's lips curved upward into a smile, and she finally let out a sigh of relief in her heart.

"But how strong do you think your mother's mental capacity is right now?" Su Zhe calmly countered. "Strong enough to let you have both?"

"Even if I only acknowledge one, she won't be much better off," Xu Qingzhu said. "I will acknowledge her while also not separating from the Sheng family. That's the best outcome."

Su Zhe stared at her intently. Xu Qingzhu refused to back down and stared right back.

Their eyes met. After a long while, Su Zhe said in a muffled voice, "We'll do as you say."

In the end, he compromised for Su Yao's sake.

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This meal went fairly smoothly.

Su Zhe had a fiery temper, but Meng Tong's elegant temperament could make him calm down.

All in all, he was a husband who was wrapped around his wife's finger.¹

Meng Tong was kind and personable, speaking with proper measure. During the meal, she asked about some things from Xu Qingzhu's upbringing and occasionally complimented her on how beautiful she was.

In such an atmosphere, it was hard not to have things go smoothly.

When they were about to leave, Xu Qingzhu added both of them on WeChat. When changing the contact names, she hesitated for a moment, but in the end changed them to "Uncle" and "Aunt."

Su Zhe asked when she would have time to return to the Su family, or they could all meet up for a meal together as a homecoming celebration.

Xu Qingzhu thought briefly. "This Sunday evening?"

To give everyone some time to mentally prepare and accept things.

Su Zhe nodded in agreement.

Afterward, Xu Qingzhu drove away, while Su Zhe and Meng Tong stood in place.

Su Zhe couldn't help but sigh with emotion. "Back then, Yaoyao was just like this."

Spirited and confident.

Although she was often not good with words at home, once she was in her area of expertise, it was like she became a different person.

Meng Tong held his hand. "Life is unpredictable."

Yes, life is unpredictable.

So the most important thing to do is cherish the present.

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1. "妻管嚴" (qī guǎn yán) literally means "strictly controlled by wife" - a humorous Chinese term for a husband who is obedient to his wife, similar to the English expression "henpecked husband" but often used more lightheartedly. ⇐

Chapter 79-2

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When Xu Qingzhu returned to Shallow Water Bay, Liang Shi was standing at the entrance in a daze.

Only when she saw her car driving in did Liang Shi slowly raise her hand and wave. She didn't look like she was in a good mood.

Now she finally understood what Liang Shi meant by "about to explode."

It was rare to see such an expression on Liang Shi's face—a bit restless, her hair casually tied into a low ponytail, left to blow in the wind.

"You're back," Liang Shi said. "Go pack your things."

Xu Qingzhu nodded. "Then wait for me a bit."

"Do you have a lot of things?" Liang Shi asked.

"Not much," Xu Qingzhu said. "Just some clothes."

Liang Shi followed behind Xu Qingzhu upstairs. She didn't go inside, just stood at the top of the stairs, but she didn't look at the living room at all.

Xu Qingzhu couldn't help but ask, "Teacher Liang, do you have germaphobia?"

Liang Shi was still in a daze and hadn't snapped out of it. "Huh?"

Then she shook her head, but then nodded again. "A little bit."

"Then why are you so anxious right now?" Xu Qingzhu asked. "Is it purely because those people came into the house?"

"Yes," Liang Shi said. "I just feel like this place could have people coming in at any time. It doesn't feel safe at all."

So it was a lack of security.

Xu Qingzhu acknowledged with an "oh" and packed her things even faster.

Neither of them had many belongings—two suitcases and some miscellaneous items.

Then they left that night and went to a hotel.

The suite that Liang Shi had spent a fortune on was on a high floor. After entering, one could overlook the entire city—the intricate transportation network, the bustling traffic, the bright lights. It looked absolutely beautiful.

It was enough to lift one's spirits.

Liang Shi sat on the hotel sofa, her restlessness finally soothed.

She took a big gulp of water. Her two long legs were crossed on the sofa. After relaxing, she looked toward Xu Qingzhu, who was standing by the window admiring the view, and finally remembered to ask about what had happened that evening.

"How did your discussion go?" Liang Shi asked. "Did it work out?"

"Mm." Xu Qingzhu turned her head and smiled. "Very smoothly."

"Are we going directly to the new place tomorrow?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi nodded. "Yes. I won't go to the company tomorrow morning. Let's move first."

The shock she had received today was too great. She needed time to recover.

This behavior actually surprised Xu Qingzhu greatly. She had thought Liang Shi would choose to drop off their things in the morning and then go to work.

Facing Xu Qingzhu's astonished gaze, Liang Shi explained, "I already submitted my resignation letter today, so tomorrow is my last day of work. It should be... fine."

She paused for a moment, then shrugged. "It doesn't matter anymore."

"I thought you would stick it out until your last day at work," Xu Qingzhu said. "But this is nice too. You can get some good rest."

"That's not it." Liang Shi looked at her, her brow furrowing again, and said gently, "I need time."

"What do you mean?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

"I don't know if you understand, but when I came back, there was a group of people standing in the living room. They might have even gone into my room, my bathroom, my washroom." As Liang Shi spoke, her voice was strained, with an almost imperceptible tremor. "It's just... just..."

After stumbling twice, Liang Shi finally let out a heavy breath. "I feel like their shadows are everywhere in that house. So I can't go to work in this state. It would affect others."

Xu Qingzhu's expression froze. She slowly walked over to the sofa, approaching Liang Shi, but didn't say anything.

She was standing while Liang Shi was sitting—a looking-down angle. Liang Shi was wearing a loose crew-neck sweatshirt in a lotus root white color that complemented her skin tone beautifully.

The light made her dyed brown hair gleam. A thin layer of sweat had seeped out on the tip of her nose, and the tip of her nose was a bit red, which didn't quite match the rest of her complexion.

But... it was rather cute.

Cute?

When this word appeared in Xu Qingzhu's mind, it startled her.

How... could one use "cute" to describe an Alpha?

But... she really was cute.

Xu Qingzhu wavered on the scale between reason and emotion, and before long, she chose emotion.

Liang Shi was usually so easy-going—no matter what you wanted to do, she would say okay, okay, okay. As long as you had a problem, she would help you solve it.

She clearly hadn't been by her side for very long, yet she gave people the illusion that "you can completely rely on me because I'm very strong."

Someone like that seemed impervious to harm, without any weaknesses.

She had never seen such an expression on her face before, so this little bit of restlessness seemed precious, and also cute and charming.

Liang Shi was still stumbling through her thoughts, trying to figure out how to describe her somewhat neurotic state, when she suddenly noticed that Xu Qingzhu was standing right beside her, looking at her with a... very complicated expression.

Her gaze held indulgence and tolerance, and also a hint of mischief... there was even something indescribable in it.

Liang Shi: "?"

"Teacher Xu." Liang Shi was startled and instinctively shrank back, then showed a helpless expression after being startled. "What are you doing?"

She sounded a bit aggrieved.

Xu Qingzhu said, "Getting closer to you so I can hear more clearly."

"I can't really explain it." Liang Shi shook her head. "This is beyond my ability to put into words. Anyway, it's just... really annoying and disgusting."

She took a deep breath and adjusted her emotions. "Alright, don't worry about me. Go wash up and sleep. You must be tired after being busy all day."

"Why shouldn't I worry about you?" Xu Qingzhu sat down beside her, her tone casual. "You haven't finished talking yet."

"I've finished," Liang Shi said. "That's all there is."

"What about the story behind it?" Xu Qingzhu asked, turning to look at her. "It's impossible to have this kind of psychological response for no reason. Have you encountered this kind of situation before?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She was silent for two seconds, then asked, "Teacher Xu, have you ever considered becoming a psychologist?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

"I have over ten years of experience with psychological counseling," Xu Qingzhu said. "You could say illness makes a good doctor.¹ You can understand it that way if you want."

Liang Shi: "..."

After two moments of speechlessness, Liang Shi said helplessly, "It's nothing major. It's all in the past. Go rest."

Liang Shi kept urging her, but Xu Qingzhu wouldn't leave. She even grabbed Liang Shi's hand when Liang Shi reached out to push her away.

Her fingertips caressed Liang Shi's wrist, pressing right on her pulse point. She said in a low voice, "I want to hear about these little things."

Liang Shi suddenly paused.

Those cool fingers pressed on her pulse, gently pressing down, making even her tailbone go numb.

Liang Shi swallowed instinctively, and all the words she was about to say were swallowed back down.

The lights in this hotel living room weren't very bright—a dim yellow color. The two of them were already sitting close together. Now, with their eyes meeting, Liang Shi could clearly see Xu Qingzhu's features.

Her lips were the color of honey peach pink, glistening with a watery gleam. The tip of her nose was pert, her nose bridge straight. The space between her eyes was just right. Her dark pupils gazed at her with exceptional tenderness, as if her entire heart was placed on you.

1. "久病成醫" (jiǔ bìng chéng yī) is a Chinese proverb meaning "long illness makes a doctor" - the idea that someone who has been ill for a long time gains medical knowledge through their experience. Xu Qingzhu is implying that her extensive experience as a patient in psychological counseling has given her insight into psychology. ⇐

Chapter 79-3

Liang Shi subconsciously licked her lips lightly, her tongue tip brushing past the corner of her lips.

Xu Qingzhu's fingers caressed her pulse point again. Her cool, clear voice sounded by her ear, carrying an almost imperceptible alluring undertone. "Teacher Liang, tell me."

Just two simple words, yet they seemed to echo repeatedly in Liang Shi's mind.

Especially the three characters she called out before that—slow and unhurried, the tone rising slightly, yet dropping again at the end. Liang Shi wasn't sure if it was her imagination, but it sounded like she was acting coquettish.

Liang Shi's heart suddenly melted into a complete mess.

The heart that had been tense all evening finally truly relaxed at this moment.

Liang Shi looked at Xu Qingzhu and suddenly smiled. The corners of her mouth lifted, her head tilted back against the sofa, and her body's center of gravity shifted backward, bringing Xu Qingzhu's body back with her.

The two of them fell onto the sofa together, looking like they were snuggling against each other.

Xu Qingzhu naturally let her head rest on Liang Shi's shoulder.

Clearly, Liang Shi's body stiffened, but she didn't say anything.

"Do you really want to hear?" Liang Shi lowered her voice and asked. Her voice carried infinite tenderness and affection.

Xu Qingzhu's fingers closed together, resting on her wrist as if taking her pulse. She responded softly, "Mm."

"Once when I came home, I found three men inside." Liang Shi said. "They had pried open my security window, and they were going through my things. After I saw them, I ran, then called the police. But they weren't caught. I moved afterward and installed three layers of locks. After that incident, I never gave anyone my house keys or passwords. When I'm there, other people can come to my place. But if I'm not there, no one is allowed in."

This story was told in a dry, straightforward manner—not a single adjective, no sense of atmosphere whatsoever.

The way Liang Shi told it, it didn't even feel dangerous.

But the actual situation at the time was that Liang Shi was only seventeen years old and hadn't yet emerged from the pain of losing her closest family member.

A young girl came to the big city to make her way. She finally found a job and rented a basement apartment. It was dark and damp, and in the middle of the night, she could hear mice squeaking inside the wall panels, as if complaining about the poor environment.

That basement had only one window—the sole window that served as the basement's ventilation opening. It was also the only place that ensured this basement could get sunlight during the brightest part of noon.

The installed security window was old and shabby. All it took was a wrench or pliers to open it.

In that prosperous metropolis, there were countless people like her renting basement apartments.

She was just one of the most ordinary among the masses.

Perhaps it was her optimism that kept her from being beaten down by life.

Even during the hardest times, she could still find joy amidst the suffering.

But that day, when she turned the lock and found three burly men standing in her room rummaging through her things, her entire scalp went numb.

Her undergarments were being held in those men's hands, thrown on the ground. The little money she had was fished out from her clothes pockets. The blanket she had folded so neatly was spread out in a mess.

In that space of barely more than ten square meters, everywhere she looked, nothing had been spared.

Those men even let out sinister laughs when they saw her. They weren't afraid at all.

Why would they be afraid?

She was just a powerless young girl.

Fortunately, she reacted fast enough and took off running.

Having trained in sprinting during middle and high school, she burst out with astonishing strength at that moment. She ran all the way outside, out of her old residential compound, and into the police station across the street.

For a period of time after that, it was her nightmare.

Many nights she couldn't sleep because she dreamed about that incident. That's why she never allowed anyone to set foot in her personal territory without her permission.

After first transmigrating here, it had taken her a while to adjust to living with Xu Qingzhu.

But also because she was so busy, with so many things to think about every day, her mild germaphobia hadn't been very severe.

She only gave a brief summary of the incident without going into specific details.

It happened many years ago. There was no need to make Xu Qingzhu worry along with her.

But clearly, what Liang Shi described didn't happen at the Liang family home.

As for where it did happen, Xu Qingzhu didn't ask.

Although she was a bit curious, now wasn't the right time to ask about it.

Chapter 79-4

Xu Qingzhu only said, "And then?"

"There is no 'and then,'" Liang Shi said. "That's everything."

"Your storytelling is pretty boring," Xu Qingzhu teased. "It was originally quite scary."

"It was alright, just really annoying," Liang Shi said. "Anyway, it's all in the past."

She spoke as if it were nothing, but Xu Qingzhu was holding her pulse and knew that her heartbeat had quickened while she was telling the story.

Xu Qingzhu didn't expose her.

Afterward, the atmosphere was very quiet. Xu Qingzhu leaned on Liang Shi's shoulder and told her about what had happened that evening, also mentioning Meng Tong.

And that they would be having dinner together on Sunday evening.

Liang Shi was surprised. "I have to go too?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded. "Of course. Did you think you could get out of it?"

"Alright then, I'll go too," Liang Shi said.

"You don't want to?" Xu Qingzhu's elbow jabbed her waist. Liang Shi felt a bit ticklish and immediately reached out to block her elbow, but Xu Qingzhu discovered her weak spot.

"Teacher Liang, you're ticklish?" Xu Qingzhu hooked up a playful smile, her tone mysterious.

Liang Shi immediately sensed danger. She shook her head. "How could I be?"

But when she wasn't paying attention, Xu Qingzhu's hand tickled her waist. It was like someone had pressed her laugh acupoint—Liang Shi grabbed at her hand while laughing. "Stop it..."

But Xu Qingzhu's movements were like a nimble snake, moving around Liang Shi's waist, making it impossible for Liang Shi to catch her. Especially since she was being poked and couldn't stop laughing—she laughed until tears came out.

Liang Shi's body went limp and she fell backward onto the sofa. Left with no choice, she could only beg for mercy. "Teacher Xu, spare me."

Xu Qingzhu's hand rested on her waist, her fingers moved slightly, slowing down by a beat—just enough for Liang Shi to catch her.

Liang Shi's hands firmly grabbed hers. Without thinking, she used a bit of force and pulled Xu Qingzhu's entire body down, making her crash into her.

This caused Liang Shi to let out a muffled grunt. Xu Qingzhu's body shifted to the side and ended up at the edge of the sofa.

The narrow sofa could only accommodate two people holding each other tightly.

Suddenly, the laughter stopped. Their eyes met.

Xu Qingzhu's body was suspended at the edge of the sofa, about to fall off at any moment.

"I'm going to fall," Xu Qingzhu said in a muffled voice.

Startled, Liang Shi immediately reached out to pull her back, but ended up wrapping her arm around her waist. Their bodies pressed tightly together.

Liang Shi had just let go when Xu Qingzhu leaned in even closer. The hand that had just gained freedom rested on her waist, holding her tightly. Her head buried in the crook of Liang Shi's shoulder as she said softly, "Our Teacher Liang has worked hard. May you always be happy from now on."

Liang Shi: "..."

Her hand that was suspended in mid-air, fingers moving slightly like playing piano in the air, finally descended in resignation a few seconds later.

After the playful commotion, her hair had come loose. The hair tie had gone who knows where. Her brown long hair cascaded down, even covering Xu Qingzhu's black hair. A few strands were tangled together.

In the narrow space, one could only hear the sound of the wind blowing against the window frame outside, rustling softly, along with the intertwined sounds of their breathing and heartbeats.

Xu Qingzhu's slender, fair hand rested on Liang Shi's shoulder blade, moving from top to bottom. Her cool, clear voice carried a hint of tenderness as she coaxed softly, "No one will invade your personal territory anymore. I'll protect you."

Liang Shi's throat felt like it was blocked by something—sour and astringent, unable to speak.

After a long while, she lowered her head and buried it in Xu Qingzhu's hair, smelling the fresh orange scent from the tips of her hair. It was crisp and pleasant, making one feel incredibly at ease.

Liang Shi's voice was slow and dull, muffled. "Okay."

It was enough to melt one's heart.

Chapter 79-5

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An unexpected phone call jolted Liang Shi awake just as she was drifting off to sleep. She fumbled groggily for her phone but touched the back of the person in her arms instead.

Her back was slender beyond belief.

Liang Shi suddenly snapped fully awake, and Xu Qingzhu also sat up, shaking her head. She looked like she had just woken up too.

The phone was on the coffee table. Liang Shi reached over and grabbed it. Xu Qingzhu tilted her head and leaned against the sofa, her two legs curled up, hugging her knees as she sat.

Liang Shi picked up the phone and glanced at it, finding that it was Zhao Xuning.

She answered, her voice carrying the hoarseness of someone who had just woken up. "What is it?"

"You were sleeping?" Zhao Xuning was surprised.

Liang Shi made a sound of acknowledgment. "What's wrong?"

"When are you moving?" Zhao Xuning asked.

Liang Shi yawned. Halfway through, she covered her mouth. Physiological tears squeezed at the corners of her eyes. Only then did she answer, "Tomorrow morning."

"Isn't tomorrow a workday?" Zhao Xuning said. "I thought you'd move on Saturday."

Liang Shi said, "Plans changed. I won't be going to work tomorrow morning. I'll just go in the afternoon to do a handover."

"Then do you have anything else to do after you finish moving tomorrow morning?"

"No. Do you need something?"

Zhao Xuning paused on her end, silent for two seconds before saying, "Help you move."

Liang Shi: "???"

This sudden act of kindness startled away all of Liang Shi's drowsiness. She asked in surprise, "Are you okay?"

Zhao Xuning immediately said coldly, "Never mind then."

"You can help," Liang Shi said.

Zhao Xuning: "...You sound so reluctant. Forget it."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi couldn't keep it up anymore and just said to her directly, "Dr. Zhao, you being like this all of a sudden is really scary. You might as well just say you need my help with something."

Zhao Xuning: "There is a small favor I need."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi laughed silently. She realized that the world of geniuses might just be strange like this.

But somehow adorable in a peculiar way.

Liang Shi said, "There we go. What's the favor?"

"My cousin needs to do an assignment for his photography elective. Can you be his model?" Zhao Xuning said. "You can be paid for it."

"Your cousin?" Liang Shi thought about it for a moment and remembered the one she had seen outside the concert hall last time. "Isn't that Sister Ying's brother? Why doesn't he ask Sister Ying to be his model?"

"He wants someone tall, over 170 cm," Zhao Xuning said. "Also someone who's a good clothes hanger and can pull off multiple styles of clothing, including two-dimensional styles and some other quirky styles. And they need to be photogenic."

Liang Shi: "..."

Hearing the first part, she thought Zhao Xuning could do it too.

But hearing the latter part...

That really wouldn't work.

Zhao Xuning's usual clothing style was too minimalist. Liang Shi had only ever seen her in a white lab coat and casual clothes.

The color combinations never exceeded three colors.

She looked like a research scientist.

Zhao Xuning had helped her out, so she naturally couldn't refuse. Besides, she had time, so she agreed.

"Thanks," Zhao Xuning said. "I'm off tomorrow. I'll help you move, and after we're done, I'll take you to the shoot. There will be payment."

Liang Shi laughed. "Then thank you, Dr. Zhao, for finding me a part-time job."

Zhao Xuning: "..."

Setting everything else aside, Zhao Xuning now felt that Liang Shi's emotional intelligence had improved by more than just a little.

The phone call ended on a fairly pleasant note.

Meanwhile, Xu Qingzhu beside her had also woken up. She was scrolling through her phone, looking at something.

Liang Shi glanced at her phone—it wasn't even nine-thirty yet. But the atmosphere earlier had been so nice that she and Xu Qingzhu had actually fallen asleep in each other's arms.

Fallen asleep...

Although it wasn't "sleeping together" in the traditional sense.

But... it was in the literal sense.

The physical contact between them seemed to be increasing more and more—just some unconscious...

Liang Shi didn't resist it. She even quite liked it.

Chapter 79-6

Although Xu Qingzhu's personality was a little bit cold, her heart was very soft, and her body was also very soft.

In the cold season, holding a soft person in your arms and snuggling together for warmth was indeed something that brought physical pleasure.

Liang Shi didn't dwell on it too much. She only knew that the shock she had received that evening from those strangers was now all better.

She had originally been too angry to feel hungry, but now that she had relaxed, she felt her stomach protesting at her nonstop. So she opened the food delivery app and asked Xu Qingzhu, "What do you want to eat?"

Xu Qingzhu said very naturally, "I already ordered."

Liang Shi: "?"

"Spicy crawfish, barbecue, two cups of milk tea, and some... snacks," Xu Qingzhu said. "Is there anything you don't eat?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She shook her head in a daze, thinking to herself: How come it was all stuff she wanted to order?

Xu Qingzhu continued looking straight ahead with an expressionless face, and casually turned on the TV. "Teacher Liang, what movie shall we watch?"

"Whatever's on," Liang Shi said.

The two of them put some distance between themselves again. Liang Shi stole a few glances at Xu Qingzhu. Seeing that she had no reaction, she also remained still.

But when the movie started, Liang Shi discovered: "..."

It was a horror movie.

The dim environment, the terrifying sound effects, the frightened protagonist...

All together, it created a sense of fear. Liang Shi was completely numb. Her hands resting on the sofa were ice cold, but she was too embarrassed to say anything.

In contrast, Xu Qingzhu was watching with great interest, without the slightest hint of fear on her face.

Liang Shi: "..."

A few minutes later, Xu Qingzhu shifted closer to Liang Shi.

The crisp, fresh scent of oranges reached her nose. Liang Shi suddenly asked, "What brand is your shampoo?"

Xu Qingzhu stared at the TV screen. A faint, eerie wailing sound was coming from inside. Her voice covered the TV. "Just something I randomly bought at a cosmetics store in the mall."

Liang Shi: "Alright."

"I still have another bottle," Xu Qingzhu said. "I'll give it to you later."

"Okay, thanks."

Liang Shi's voice was trembling at the end. She didn't even dare to look at the screen.

The protagonist on TV had entered an empty forest, with the risk of a jump scare at any moment.

When that eerie sound rang out, Xu Qingzhu covered Liang Shi's eyes.

Liang Shi: "?"

Then the music changed, and what followed was the jump scare that Liang Shi feared most.

After that shot passed, Xu Qingzhu lowered her hand and said, "Oops, I covered the wrong eyes."

When the movie was twenty minutes in, Xu Qingzhu hugged Liang Shi's arm. "Teacher Liang, let me borrow your arm."

Liang Shi: "Okay."

Xu Qingzhu said, "I'm a little scared."

Liang Shi: "..."

I totally believe you.¹

But she thanked Xu Qingzhu silently for not exposing her last bit of stubbornness.

Watching a horror movie in a bright environment, with someone pressed close beside her, it seemed... not so scary anymore.

1. This is said sarcastically. The original "我信了你的邪" is a colloquial expression meaning "I'd be crazy to believe you" or "Yeah, right." Liang Shi clearly doesn't believe Xu Qingzhu is actually scared, recognizing that Xu Qingzhu is using it as an excuse to comfort her instead. ⇐

Chapter 79-7

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The late-night snacks were exceptionally filling. Most of the snacks Xu Qingzhu had ordered were puffed snacks.

Milk tea and cola mixed together, and the hotel fridge even had cold beer. Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu split a can.

Things that she might not touch more than twice in three months on a normal day—Liang Shi had eaten her fill of them all in one night.

After eating, she felt the happiness that food brought her.

And while ordering the snacks, Xu Qingzhu had also bought a door stopper. She attached it to the door so that the door could only be opened from the inside.

Xu Qingzhu helped Liang Shi install it on the door. After testing it, she said, "Now you don't have to be afraid anymore."

Liang Shi said helplessly, "Thank you, Teacher Xu."

Xu Qingzhu leaned against the door and smiled casually and lazily. "You're welcome."

That night, Liang Shi had recalled unpleasant memories from the past and watched a horror movie, but she had a pleasant dream when she slept.

After sleeping soundly, she was completely satisfied. Early the next morning, she went with Xu Qingzhu to have breakfast near the hotel.

The place they had been living before was a bit remote, so there were no breakfast shops nearby at all. The two of them could only eat at home.

Now, occasionally eating a meal at a small restaurant outside, surrounded by people coming and going—all workers who would be heading to their jobs soon—they blended into the crowd and ate with complete satisfaction.

After they finished eating, Xu Qingzhu pulled out a tissue and handed it to Liang Shi. Liang Shi was startled.

Xu Qingzhu held the tissue and wiped the corner of Liang Shi's mouth, teasing, "Teacher Liang, were you sneaking food?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She hurriedly took the tissue. "Thanks."

Xu Qingzhu's tone was flat. "Teacher Liang is so polite."

Liang Shi: "..."

"Teacher Xu is so passive-aggressive," Liang Shi retorted.

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow. "Is that so? Teacher Liang hasn't seen much of the world."

Liang Shi: "..."

Early in the morning, the two of them went back and forth with a few quips, but both knew when to stop.

On the way back to the hotel, Liang Shi suddenly thought of something. "There are a lot of shops like this near Zhao Xuning's neighborhood. We won't have to make breakfast ourselves every day anymore."

"That's right," Xu Qingzhu said. "Teacher Liang can rest."

Liang Shi: "...Mainly, Teacher Xu won't have to compete with me anymore."

Xu Qingzhu: "Can't help it. Teacher Liang's schedule is too healthy. I have to keep up."

Liang Shi: "Teacher Xu just needs to go to bed early."

Xu Qingzhu: "Well, once you start filming, let's see who goes to bed earlier."

Liang Shi: "..."

As they were talking, they had already walked to Xu Qingzhu's car. Liang Shi opened the car door for her. "Teacher Xu, off to work. Have a safe trip."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She chuckled lightly. "Can't win the argument so you're sending me away?"

Liang Shi nodded. "This is called changing the battlefield. Teacher Xu, work hard, okay?"

Okay?

That was also somewhat passive-aggressive.

But Xu Qingzhu tossed her bag into the car, reached out to pick off a dead leaf that had fallen on Liang Shi's shoulder, and patted her shoulder in passing. She had the demeanor of someone giving earnest advice. "Teacher Liang, remember you still have to go to work this afternoon."

"Remember you still have to go to work this afternoon"?

Even more passive-aggressive.

After Liang Shi sent her off, she stood in place watching her car drive away into the distance.

Suddenly she heard someone sigh emotionally, "As expected, beautiful people are together with beautiful people."

"You only saw that they're beautiful. Damn, didn't you notice how good their relationship is?" another person said.

Liang Shi turned around and found it was a man and a woman who appeared to be a couple.

The two were still bickering.

Liang Shi: "..."

She realized that in this world, although it was an ABO worldview where people were divided into six genders, Alphas and Omegas were the minority. Betas made up the majority of the total population. But it seemed like there were very few Betas around her. The original owner's sister... no wait, Liang Wanwan was a Beta.

Sun Meirou seemed to be a Beta too.

The rest were rarely seen.

It was also hard to tell them apart by appearance.

Except for the pheromones released during heat periods, it was difficult to distinguish otherwise.

AO relationships made up the majority, but there were also AB relationships and BO relationships. Only AA relationships and OO relationships couldn't happen due to the principle of pheromone repulsion between the same types.

But there were still some who dated. They just needed to undergo a secondary differentiation surgery, and the technology nowadays was very mature.

In the Beta world, male-female relationships were still the majority.

Two women standing together was still more eye-catching.

Especially when two beautiful women stood together.

Liang Shi now understood why she and Xu Qingzhu had been talked about—because they were too conspicuous.

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That little episode in the morning didn't affect much. Liang Shi returned to the hotel to tidy up, then took her luggage to Zhao Xuning's neighborhood.

Although Zhao Xuning didn't live in this neighborhood now, where she currently lived wasn't far from here.

Every time Liang Shi drove into this neighborhood, she couldn't help but feel emotional. They were all the same age and both came from wealthy families for generations, yet the original owner had squandered all her money, while Zhao Xuning had saved up her pocket money and bought several properties.

A lesson in—the importance of investment.

Liang Shi was still sighing with emotion on her way upstairs, but when she saw Zhao Xuning standing at the door, she stopped. She pulled her two suitcases over and couldn't help but ask, "Dr. Zhao, is this what you meant by helping me move?"

Zhao Xuning was expressionless, but her face clearly said—Isn't it?

"You could have at least come downstairs to meet me," Liang Shi said while opening the door. "You just waited here?"

Zhao Xuning: "..."

She retorted coldly, "It's not like you can't carry them yourself."

Liang Shi: "..."

"But why didn't you go in?" Liang Shi asked. "Don't you have the keys and password to this place?"

Zhao Xuning glanced at her, then handed over the spare key she had. "Remember to change the password. This is your home now. I don't have the habit of entering other people's homes without permission."